Lab 01: Windows Process-Event Triage

A safe beginner exercise using sample evidence and optional local Event Viewer inspection

Learning goals

- Distinguish an event from an alert and an incident.
- Identify key fields in a process-creation record.
- Write an evidence-based triage note without overclaiming.

SAFETY / COST Use the included sample data first; it costs nothing and changes no system settings. Only inspect logs on a device/account you are authorised to use.

Part A — Read the sample record

Open the companion file website/public/labs/windows-process-creation-samples.json, or use the sample-data download button on this lab card. It contains intentionally simplified training records with synthetic IDs. Do not treat them as live telemetry.

Field	Sample value	Interpretation
event_id	SAMPLE-4688-001	Training identifier, not a real Windows ID
windows_event_id	4688	Windows Security process-creation event ID, if auditing is configured
host	TRAINING-WIN-01	Synthetic host label
process	C:\Windows\System32\notepad.exe	Harmless example process path
user	STUDENT-LAB	Synthetic username
label	benign	Expected label for this training record

Part B — Optional local verification

1. Open Event Viewer on your own Windows computer (search the Start menu for Event Viewer).

2. Browse to Windows Logs > Security. Access may require appropriate permissions; do not change policy if you are unsure.
3. If process-creation auditing is already enabled, inspect a recently created benign process such as Notepad and locate the relevant event record.
4. If no matching event appears, use the bundled sample data. Process-creation auditing may not be enabled by default; this exercise does not require changing group policy.

Part C — Investigate the training case

The second sample is marked suspicious for the purpose of exercising a rule because its command-line field contains an encoded-command indicator. This label is a training ground truth, not proof that a real user or device is compromised.

1. Record the event type, host, user, process, and command-line context.
2. Describe the exact condition that caused the rule to match.
3. List at least two pieces of additional context you would seek in a real investigation.
4. Describe one legitimate reason administrative PowerShell may be used.
5. Write a short conclusion using “observed”, “suggests”, and “not yet confirmed” accurately.

Answer key / discussion

The benign Notepad record should not match a rule scoped to PowerShell encoded-command indicators. The labelled PowerShell training record should match if the rule checks the process name and relevant argument marker. That rule is only a triage signal; analyst review is needed to establish intent and scope.

SUCCESS CRITERIA Your note cites observable fields, explains the rule match, identifies missing evidence, and avoids claiming that a rule match alone proves malicious intent.

Further study

- Windows event auditing overview (Microsoft Learn)
- Wazuh getting started